

Risk Decision Tree & Change Request Manifest – Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

1. What is the new Risk Decision Tree and why do we need it?

The Risk Decision Tree is used to determine whether a change is low, medium, or high risk based on impact, complexity, dependencies, and testing. It ensures that changes affecting safety, flight operations, revenue, and guest experience receive the appropriate level of review, approval, and visibility prior to implementation.

2. If a change touches a Ground Stop application or Day of Travel service, is it automatically considered HIGH risk?

Yes. Any change that impacts a Ground Stop application or Day of Travel service (Account, BTS, ABD, CSA Mobile) is automatically classified as high risk, even if the change is small or routine, because these systems directly affect safety, flight operations, revenue, and guest experience.

3. If a Standard Change is for a Ground Stop application or Day of Travel service, is it still LOW risk?

No. Even if a change normally qualifies as a low-risk Standard Change, it becomes high risk when it impacts a Ground Stop application or Day of Travel service (Account, BTS, ABD, CSA Mobile). These changes must be submitted as a normal Change Request and not through the Standard Change or GULD process.

4. Does the Decision Tree's reference to "shared services" include APIs consumed by multiple clients?

Yes. Any API consumed by multiple applications or teams is considered a shared service under the Risk Decision Tree.

5. Will MEDIUM/HIGH risk changes require CAB approval? Is offline CAB approval possible?

All medium and high-risk changes require CAB approval. Approval is typically provided during Thursday CAB meetings, with limited offline CAB approvals. Change Requests must be submitted by 6:00 PM PST on Friday with Director approval to be included in Monday VP review.

6. How do I obtain offline CAB approval?

Send an email using the Offline CAB Approval [email template](#) available on the [Alaska Change Management Portal](#).

7. Are additional CAB meetings planned due to increased change volume?

This is under discussion but not yet finalized. Increased CAB capacity may be required as more changes are classified as medium or high risk.

8. How will Change Requests (CRs) be flagged for Monday review?

Each Friday, all Change Requests scheduled for the upcoming Monday–Sunday are exported from Cherwell and ServiceNow. CRs must be submitted by 6:00 PM PST Friday, be scheduled in the upcoming week, and have Director approval for medium/high risk. Exports occur at 7:00 PM PST Friday, and VPs review the list on Monday.

9. What is the Change Request Manifest and why do we need it?

The Change Request Manifest is the complete package of information required to evaluate, approve, implement, and validate a change. It serves as the single source of truth and includes the Change Request and all supporting documentation.

Change Request (in Cherwell or ServiceNow) captures details like:

- Description & Justification
- Risk
- Schedule
- Approvals

In addition to the details on the request, attach the following documents to the request:

- Runbook ([ITS Operations Runbook Template.docx](#))
- Diagrams (i.e., logical, physical, detailed architecture diagrams, dataflow and workflow diagrams) (*)
- Deployment/Implementation plan (**)
- Rollback/Backout plan (**)

- Test plan and validated results (**)
- Communication plan (**)
- Additional approvals (i.e., Director, MD, VP, Business)
- Other documents as needed to support the request (i.e., screenshot of no activity on a server/service if the request is to decommission a server/service)

(*) If the diagram is too complex to include in the runbook, attach diagram file(s) to the request

(**) These items are part of the request, but if the plan is too long to enter in the request form, attach applicable document(s) to the request

10. Does the Runbook replace existing documents?

Yes. Teams should consolidate documents such as System Summary and Triage & Troubleshooting into the Runbook, which serves as a step-by-step operational guide.

11. What is the purpose of the test plan and validated results?

The test plan documents either pre-production testing results or post-implementation validation when pre-testing is not possible.

12. How do I adjust the risk of my request in Cherwell?

Update the Risk Assessment Questionnaire fields in Cherwell. Selecting Complex or Very Complex will raise the calculated risk.

13. Need help or more information?

Policies, guidance, templates, and support are available on the [Alaska Change Management Portal](https://alaskaair.sharepoint.com/sites/ITSCChangeManagement): <https://alaskaair.sharepoint.com/sites/ITSCChangeManagement>